

Clockwise from left The UNESCO listed Renaissance styled Kronborg castle is a pilgrimage for lovers of fine architecture; The Chapel of Skulls, built in baroque style is adorned with thousands of skulls and skeletal remains; Ksiaz Castle is fondly referred to as the Pearl of Lower Silesia.



Star-studded Lower Silesia, Poland

The year 2024, put new places on the travelling map. Lower Silesia, a crucible of art and culture, is one such gem. Even if you have a few days to add to your Polish itinerary, the places on this list (that make a unique road-trip) are worth seeking out.

I begin at the Chapel of Skulls in Czermna. Inspired by Rome's Capuchin Crypt, the walls and ceilings of this unique chapel are barnacled with human skulls and bones. The chapel serves both as a shrine for the dead and as poignant reminder of our own mortality. Nearby Klodzko Fortress, one of the finest examples of 18th century defensive architecture, is engaging. Not just with the views of the striking town and surrounds from its terrace, but also for its underground immense labyrinthine system of tunnels, each once serving their own purpose–defense, communication, storage.

Within driving distance is the whimsical Ksiaz Castle, fondly referred to as the Pearl of Lower Silesia. It was recently used as filming set for the Oscar award winning film, Zone of Interest. This lavishly ornamented palace, studded with objects d'art, hosts a blend of architectural styles that reflect various periods in its layered history. An Underground Tourist Route, now open to the public, allows visitors to explore a mysterious underground complex, built here under Hitler's orders in World War II. Engulfing the castle, are large tracts of resplendent gardens and forested land, that allow for introspection on the horrors of war, while inviting sublime appreciation of the treasures thrown up on a road less travelled.

